packs that mimic those made in a gym," says Dr Amit Gupta, founder of Divine Cosmetic Surgery in Delhi's GK2 locality.

Artificial intelligence has also had a transformative effect in personalisation and precision, say experts. "AI-driven skin tools can evaluate the condition of the skin, providing a magnified perspective that the naked eye can easily miss. 3D imaging technology creates a more realistic and detailed model, offering pre-operative planning and visualising desired outcomes," says Dr Geeta Grewal, founder and CMD, 9 Muses Wellness Clinic.

The way a surgeon preps for a procedure today reflects all this. Instead of consulting books, hand-drawn figures, or the internet, they now consult incredibly precise real-life models of the body part that they are going to work upon. This is done for both non-surgical and minimally invasive procedures. "Virtual 3D surgery platforms are very helpful in planning jaw surgeries that can change the entire facial structure, like chin advancement or jaw reshaping. I often get a 3D model printed of a patient's jaw and perform a mock surgery on it to get the angles and advancement measures," explains Dr Sunil Choudhary, principal director & chief of plastic surgery, Max Super Speciality Hospital, Saket.

THE NON-SURGICAL REVOLUTION

Two huge non-surgical technology boons have been endoscopic procedures and the use of radio frequencies. "Endoscopic facial plastic surgery has revolutionised face and forehead lift surgeries," says Dr Choudhary. "The endoscopy magnifies and makes it possible to operate through scalp incisions. I perform endoscopic facial plastic surgery routinely with excellent results and patients love it as it is scarless."

Similarly, ultrasonic energy—which uses ultrasound waves on tissues—has changed liposuction. "Ultrasonic liposuction emulsifies body fat like milky liquid which then can be sucked out smoothly through motorised liposuction cannulas. Together, the two technologies have made body contouring safer with less blood loss and more predictable due to better body shape and skin shrinkage," adds Choudhary.

Another emerging non-surgical tool is microneedling, which involves repeated puncturing of the skin. It is used for improving skin texture, reducing scars and boosting collagen, the skin's primary building block. "We use an eight-step procedure that stimulates three times more collagen production in a single session, and works on scars, texture, dark spots, acne and hyperpigmentation. It's perfect for clients seeking smoother, healthier-looking skin," says Gaurav Singh, owner of Luxury Aesthetics in Delhi.



"AI-driven skin tools can evaluate skin condition, providing a magnified perspective missed by the eye. 3D imaging creates a more realistic model, offering pre-operative planning for desired outcomes"

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While these procedures certainly don't come cheap, many consider them as a worthwhile investment. "The costs might be higher but operation costs will reduce in the long run," says Dr Choudhary. The popular minimally invasive nose jobs can cost between Rs 25,000 and Rs 100,000; breast enlargements can go up to Rs 2 lakh; creating six packs can be up to Rs 4 lakh and permanent derma fillers for the face can set one back by Rs 30,000-70,000. "I had a client who set up a mutual fund so that the money would go towards her liposuction," says Dr Prakhar Shrivastava, a fat-reduction specialist from Bengaluru.

DANGER OF ADDICTION

What happens when the allure of looking good takes over your life? Indeed, people can get 'addicted' to plastic surgeries. This happens to individuals who suffer from body dysmorphic disorder (BDD), where they constantly worry about how they look. Social anxiety, low self-esteem and confidence and a perceived decrease in physical attractiveness are part of the condition. "If such a person has the means to go under the knife, they are at risk of making the wrong choice just to look good, even if it is medically unsafe," says Dr Purnima Nagaraja, a psychiatrist from Hyderabad. Such people will often go shopping for surgeries. A Mumbai-based cosmetic surgeon says he is frequently visited by young women who often return a second time to say, "Can it be prettier, rounder or bigger? And I have to put my foot down and say no. To achieve that fine line between utter perfection and reality, they are willing to pay anything. However, what is perfection is not always medically wise," he says.

The risk of BDD patients getting addicted to surgeries makes it crucial that an ethical code of conduct is observed. "We have to differentiate between addiction to plastic surgery and the need for it. If someone repeatedly comes for Botox treatment, it's not addiction because the effect wears off. But if someone keeps returning for breast shaping or liposuction, it's an addiction. As a rule, if a person comes back a second time for something that is not clearly indicative, we refuse," says Dr Gupta.

This need to balance the demand for sculpting human appearances with medical ethics—the 'plastic' in plastic surgery cleaves to its Greek root *plastikos*, meaning "to change the shape or form of"—is assuming increasing importance in a world fixated with body image. Both doctors and patients are empowered by new technology that enables surgeries to be quick, safe and precise, with little side-effects or even visible signs. But a line has to be drawn somewhere. ■